

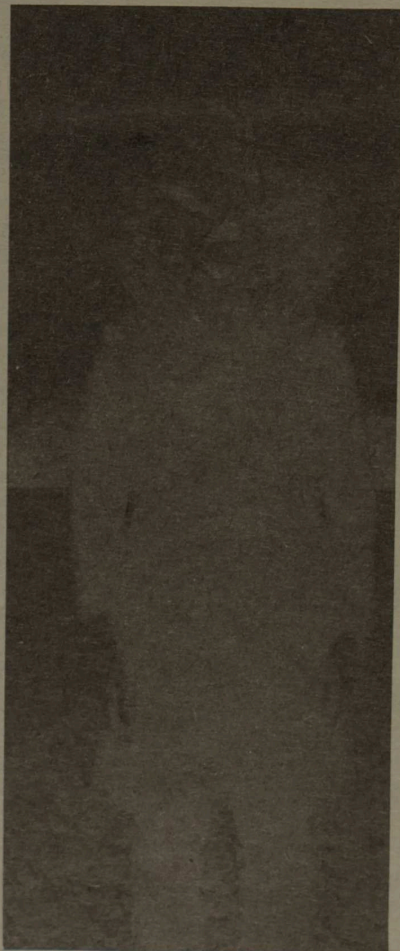
The Obsequies of the Gods

R. Incognito

*To arch over the dewy bow of hope,
and be inebriated with the euphoria of a dope.
To deceive eternity through the Cross,
or practise Communism in a frost.
Speak not of bliss and being,
But tears and laughter in the tragedy of living.
Seek not for love and giving,
but sorrow and despair in reward of seeing.*

**'In the name of God,
I can do everything ?
In the name of Man,
I can do nothing ?'**

Modern man is a forlorn clown amidst his spurious mosaic of existence: his actions are powerless, his mind dissociates from reality, his life is paved with abysmal loneliness, his agonized countenance ghastly delineates his apathy and impotence in relation to the objective world. To seek any consistent image of him will surely be futile and discouraging — his portrait is but a nihilistic one. He is but a political anarchist, a machine par excellence and a son of probability combined. The plurality of conflicting modern ideologies has compelled man to forsake his well-cherished cradle of traditional authoritarian religions, leaving him in a vexatious state of indecisive anxiety. Ethical relativism has parched his touchstone of reality to another Hiroshima. Gone are the Gods and the myths man clings to. Gone are the *jus divinum* and dogmatism man entertains. Grasped in the infinite, ever-expanding spiral of metamorphoses, he traipses like a lost child inside his labyrinthine superstructure. Only darkness and despair prevail; not even a trace of solacing light can be found. But to weep or linger in such appalling crypt is of no avail — for it can only throttle his hope slowly, aggravate his fright and anxiety and nothing else. After all, is it better still, and prouder indeed, to be a bold explorer than a mere marionette of the times? Really, modern man is adrift on the raft of the Medusa in the seething ocean of meaninglessness; he is just a rover craving for a spiritual home but is denied it. The growth of the complexity of his social institutions and his objective reality renders him insipid, creating crimes, social evils and a general disgust of life. His is a society of voluptuary, draped with brandy, dildoes and extravagant banquets. His is also a world of misery, bemused by wars, crimes and pollutions. Inequality exists everywhere. The ubiquitous scientism simply petrifies man to a huge industry of cells. Thus, to man, any objective, absolute value system is but a delusion; any frantic, zealous belief is but a myth. And delusion does not exist; myths die as well. Instead of the Cross or the Communist Manifesto, the sign of modern man is absurdity and absurdity is the very being of his world, the very stuff of his reality. Perhaps nothing can be more distressing and preposterous for him — a wanderer who realizes that the only truth in the whole wild world is that he shall never find what he seeks for. Once and for all, his actions become frozen, frigid; his existence becomes isolated — there is nothing



left for man except an incongruous, suffocating spiritual vacuum. All can he do is to jump into the fathomless vortex of mass culture, carried away by its ordeal and homogenized by its appeal. Only normlessness and anxiety dominate his life. Only Thanatos triumphs and rejoices in its relentless grin.

Such, in essence, and even more absurd, more void of meaning, is the world of modern science and philosophy. And such a preposterous and wanton world of nothingness, in no time at all, man must henceforth build a shrine for his ideals and create a humanistic religion for himself. Suppose that man is but a fortuitous conglomeration of atoms, a lone-some child of probability in the almost irreversible course of evolution with no prevision of what he is and what he shall be. Or that he is a son of the star-dusts without cause or *jus divinum* of whatever kind; that the zenith of man's strivings, his arts, his sciences, his ideals, his music will inevitably be buried in the debris of the expanding universe; and that his consciousness, his soul, his loves, and hopes, his gods and his beliefs will never survive after his brief years of life. Or suppose that time is irreversible and that the whole universe is running down with increasing entropy, by which no devout prayers, no heroism, no passionate longings, no lofty aspirations can reverse or even hope to preserve; and that any value system is arbitrary, and that truth is merely the cards of the Gods, determined solely by the vogue of the ages. Or even that all the splendour of human achievements, all the loftiest emotions, all the aspects of humanity are destined to vanish in the dusk ad infinitum. Too pessimistic indeed! Yet, all these generalizations and prognostications, if not absolutely certain, are not too far from the truth — that any religion or philosophy whatsoever, in their ephemeral course of emergence, should endorse, or else be fallen.

'The Fall of Man — the Obsequies of the Gods'

Man is not man before Adam and Eve — he was enthralled to his awful physical universe, under the mercy of the inexorable powers of Nature. For epochs, he was a creature of instinctual patterns, conditioned by his natural environment. He fed, walked, killed and reproduced without cause, and without asking a cause. He was just an unthinking animal, manipulated as toys by the Gods. Yet, however improbable, a miracle occurred — the omnipotent but blind Nature, in her secular epopee through the abysses of space, had at last brought forth a child called man, still under her dominion, but gifted with self-awareness, with knowledge of good and evil, and with an objective system of studying the handiwork of his alien and inhuman Mother. Thus, the first fall of man began — he ceased to be the mere puppets of his Lords. Despite the fact that he was tempted to lead a settled life, to practise a powerful discipline called science and to transcend his natural universe, he was still, at times, tyrannized by his physical reality. Fearful and timid as he was, and as he is, he seeks compassions

an approach to Humanistic Religion

from the Gods, which are but the higher phase of his consciousness. Moreover, knowing that he can never taste the forbidden fruit of immortality, he invents systems of theology to fulfil his vain reverie, so that after his irrevocable death, he can still inherit eternal life — to be as and with his Gods. Caught in his ultimate concern, the savage man can do nothing but imposes his own belief on others, as a system of absolute, indubitable truth. Disobedience and infidelity are regarded as the gravest sins and are supposed to deserve everlasting damnation. Thus, in the name of his Gods, the savage man can do everything. Such also is the attitude of those, who, in our age, base their belief upon any kind of dogmatic ideologies and the like. They cannot accept people. Nor can they live and let live. Only can they indulge in quixotic projects and metaphysical contemplation. Seeing the present condition is bad, they resolve to make it even worse than ever.

The birth pangs of modern agnosticism and humanism have temporarily caused man to lose his self-identity and his consciousness. But all these perverse and wicked phenomena, so called by the pious, are but the mere inception of their long-repressed nightmare — the upheaval of the iconoclastic Evolutionism and Freudism has already shattered their autistic reveries of ethnocentrism, or else theocentrism. Vicotrian Puritanism has undergone a bizarre dialectical reversal and re-emerges as Dionysian orgies; radical atheism blooms brilliantly from the bud of devout religiosity, by which the Gods are guillotined. Thus springs the second fall of man — the degeneration of man from an instinctual, helpless and emotionally morbid creature to an autonomous, independent and thinking being has paid homage to the obsequies of the Gods. Man is no creature any more. He is the Creator, the Creator of his own Fate, his own being and destiny. Man no longer conforms to the immutable necessity of determinism — once again, he is bestowed the Edenic apple of freedom. Nevertheless, his acquired free will forces him to renunciate his ultimate source of security — his refuge in authoritarian religions. There is hardly anything to guide him; he has to face his world alone; he has to cope with his nostalgia and loneliness inherent in his extra-uterine life. In his godless world, everything is possible. In his chaotic universe every entity is a reductio ad absurdum.

The Death of the Gods — the Birth of Humanity.'

To man, and to man alone, the gift of self-consciousness belongs. In spite of death, the eerie realm which every human being has to face, will occur in its inevitable march, man is still free, both to examine and to value, to act and to see. It is by its necessity, that any humanistic religion should be founded upon the unyielding despair of the soul; to defy the Gods with fierce hatred and to show blazing indifference to ordeal; to have unbending fortitude and passionate love in all good things. The answer to our age is not blowing in the wind; nor does it lie in any sacred doctrinaire books with inviolable deterministic truth. The answer to our age lies in ourselves; we can erect a religion, a shrine where man can ennoble his little days by actively transcending ourselves. Surely, it is the time for man to wean from the lethal ambrosia of dogmatism.

It is the time for man to liberate himself from the tyranny of the Gods. It is also the time for man to murder the Gods in his heart. The free man can do nothing but admit that the Gods are but his devils, for he, by his very nature, is a semipiternal rover, an agnostic wanderer with humanity at heart and indeterminism in mind.

What move me as a human being, an individual of the species Homo sapiens, are not the facets and tragedies of my experience, but the similitude of my experience with others. Upon this cornerstone of empathy, upon this concrete humanity, we can penetrate and consolidate with the emotional being of our fellow men; we can transform the vision of our mundane world into a celestial paradise; no longer do we demand that we are infallible and perfect. However, we can accept and transcend our flaw and blemish with the courage to be, without losing our starry hopes and lofty aspirations. We sometimes are enshrouded by despair and woe, agonized by the Omnipotent Fate. Many times have we faltered. Many times have we been thwarted and languished by our loss and defect, under the bondage of Self. Many times have we been veiled by our improvident outlook. Brooded by our morbid thoughts, our hopes become diminished; our senses became inebriated. Our world seems to be sombre and desperate. Yet, as our insight into life grows, we realize that we have to give; we have to inquire into the external world and transcend it. In order to perceive our complex, intricate world and to change it, we have to shake off our intellectual and moral pride; to feel with the mass, yet to stand aloof analytically; to share others' experiences, joy and sadness, yet to be aware of the objective reality. Be it ours to shed light upon them, to be emphatic with their life. Be it ours to develop a never-tiring joy of learning and giving. Let us recall that our fellow-men are ourselves. Brief their lives are, their bliss or

misery depends on us. In this absurd world of being, where we are condemned to lose our dearest today, where death triumphs in its universal doom, there is nothing left except to cherish and to give. Reality, to us, is always novel and capricious; yet we can always achieve ontological security through the tenderness of human love, the humility of independence and the merging of our sciences and humanities. Acceptance, tolerance and transcendence are our virtues. Mystical love can transform our selves completely. The exaltation of our beloved, allied with our acceptance and transcendence of the defects of humanity, can cause an existential reincarnation in our selves. The experience of other selves is always new, refreshing and is worth exploration, love and exaltation. This gives us not only a unity with our fellow-men, but also a cosmic consciousness and an existential rebirth which are but our ultimate concern, which we and the Universe exist in the highest consummation. We immediately feel that we, the human race are but One. The free man recognizes no dogma but the dogma of love. He senses no obstacle but the obstacle of bigotry. In a Universe where entropy always increases, where death is inevitable, we can do nothing but to accept it. With this enhanced sensitivity for our fellow-men, with this new level of self-awareness, we can be tragically beautiful and make our fleeting existence unique, as well as meaningful. Let us blaze with the ferment zest of life. We falter but we strive to stand. We suffer rejection but continue to give. Let us not judge people by our grudging scale of merits and demerits, but rather let us think in their own terms and extend our precious quality of empathy. In this way, we can be deeply religious, thus giving us a feeling of pantheistic ecstasy and individualized religiosity. In this way, and perhaps no other, we can be the true children of the Universe.



GOD + DOG $\Rightarrow$ ♀ + ♂ $\Rightarrow$ ♀
 CREATION, EVOLUTION or
 METAMORPHOSIS ?